

"When you start a totally new industry, the world looks at you with a question mark. **Now, those question marks are behind us**.... We are moving to take the lead"

Q. What incentives have you given big semiconductor companies and why?

See, if you look at the global benchmark, what countries our size have done is pour in billions and billions of dollars in this entire industry, because this is a strategic industry. It requires support through the inevitable vicious cycles. So, being a foundational industry, it has to be supported by government; across the world, that is the practice, and we follow the best practices of the world. We have offered incentives that are in line with the Semiconductor Mission Policy, which is supporting capital expenditure as well as the eligible investment. Some state governments have done so too. The total investment now is around $18 billion (Rs 1.6 lakh crore). So, we are going to manufacture chips, the material and the machines which make chips. That's the whole ecosystem we are working on.

Q. So far, some of the big chipmakers like TSMC, NVIDIA or Chinese manufacturers have not come to India? Why do you think this is so?

One of the big ones, [the Taiwanese company] PSMC, has collaborated with Tatas, and Micron [which is establishing a project in Sanand, Gujarat] is among the top five in the world. Others will come. When you start a totally new industry, the world looks at you with a question mark. Now, those question marks are behind us. [The Dutch company] ASML, for instance, came with a full contingent, their entire top leadership was here and they very categorically said that India is absolutely on the right track to become a semiconductor nation.

Q. When do you think we will start making them indigenously and reduce our imports?

If you look at how we have selected our 10 projects, we have covered practically every sector. As these facilities start coming online, we will meet a significant part of our domestic demand. But we must also understand that semiconductor is a global industry. It doesn't know national boundaries; each material, each component crosses multiple boundaries before it becomes a finished product. Our role is to be a trusted partner in the growth story unfolding in our country, making sure that we contribute. The way we have consolidated our forces and used our strengths, both in the public sector and the private sector, it's going to be a good journey ahead.

Q. What about skill development and job creation?

We started a talent development programme and gave the latest design tools to 278 universities. As a result, in a very short time-frame of two and a half years, students have designed chips based on the design tools they have access to, and we have used the SCL to fabricate these chips. Very few countries in the world today can claim that their university and college students can design and produce chips. It will be a huge driver of jobs.

Q. What do you reckon India's semiconductor industry will look like 5-10 years from now?

It will be a very comprehensive industry. Five years down the line, we will be manufacturing chips, we will have a lot of R&D, we will have a great equipment-manufacturing ecosystem. We will be manufacturing some of the most complex and critical new materials like silicon carbide. It is a journey which will become a very significant one in the coming years and we are moving to take the lead. ■